Massachusetts Will Vote on Allowing Smaller Homes

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Homes in Massachusetts cost a lot of money. Now **voters** there will decide on a plan to make it easier to build smaller, cheaper homes.

Many towns have rules about how big a piece of land a house must sit on. In Massachusetts, most of these rules say at least an **acre**. That is almost as big as a football field.

The plan would let homes be built on land as small as 5,000 **square feet**. That is about the size of a basketball court. The plan would not apply to Boston.

People who support it say big land rules mean fewer homes, and the homes that get built are large and **expensive**. Housing expert Andrew Mikula is leading the push. **Polls** suggest many people support it.

People against the plan say towns should make their own rules. They also doubt the homes would really be cheap. One older house on a small lot was for sale for nearly $1.3 million.

Word Treasure

voters -- People who choose leaders or decide on rules in an election.

acre -- A way to measure land; one acre is almost as big as a football field.

square feet -- A way to measure how much flat space something covers.

expensive -- Costing a lot of money.

Polls -- Surveys that ask many people what they think.

Background you need

Towns make rules about what can be built on each piece of land, including how big a house's yard must be.

When there are not enough homes for everyone, prices go up and families have a harder time finding a place to live.

In Massachusetts, voters can decide some new rules themselves by voting on them.

Break it down

WHO: Massachusetts voters, supporter Andrew Mikula and people against the plan
WHAT: A vote on letting homes be built on land as small as 5,000 square feet
WHERE: Massachusetts towns, but not Boston
WHY: Supporters say big land rules mean fewer, more expensive homes

Why it matters

Rules like this can decide whether families, maybe even yours someday, can afford a home in the town they love.

Test what you remember

1. What will Massachusetts voters decide?

- (A) Whether to close schools
- (B) Whether to allow homes on smaller pieces of land
- (C) Whether to build a new stadium
- (D) Who will be mayor of Boston

2. How much land do most rules in Massachusetts say a house needs now?

- (A) Half a basketball court
- (B) A tiny garden
- (C) At least an acre
- (D) Exactly 100 square feet

3. The plan would allow homes on land about the size of what?

- (A) A swimming pool
- (B) A basketball court
- (C) A football field
- (D) A parking space

4. Which city would the plan NOT apply to?

- (A) Boston
- (B) New York
- (C) Lexington
- (D) Every town

5. Who is leading the push for the plan?

- (A) A basketball coach
- (B) A farmer
- (C) Housing expert Andrew Mikula
- (D) The president

6. What do people against the plan say?

- (A) Towns should make their own rules
- (B) Boston should pay for it
- (C) Homes should be bigger than castles
- (D) Nobody needs homes

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: A 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Supporters: Say big land rules mean fewer homes, and the ones built are large and expensive.

2. People against the plan: Say towns should make their own rules and doubt the homes would really be cheap.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):